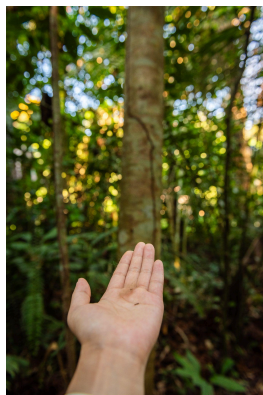


Chapter 1 — The Clever Plants

The moment I stepped into the Amazon rainforest, I was swallowed by a surge of green. Fifty thousand species of plants grow here, layered and intertwined like a colossal vertical tapestry. Sunlight, rain, and nutrients are abundant, so abundant that any seed falling to the ground seems capable of sprouting. But abundance breeds fierce competition. Even the sunlight must fight its way through tier upon tier of leaves, drifting down only as scattered, trembling flecks. Even at noon, the forest floor is wrapped in a heavy emerald dusk, as if I were walking on the bottom of the sea.



To seize sunlight, the trees race upward with every ounce of energy they have. The easiest strategy is simply to grow tall—like the balsa tree. Reaching up to thirty meters, even that height doesn't qualify as a giant here. Underfoot, the forest floor was covered with its fluffy seeds, lighter than cotton, ready to float skyward with the gentlest breeze. Perhaps only a handful will survive the rainforest's relentless competition. Yet it is these countless tiny attempts that sustain the forest's immense vitality.

